

THE MAN WHO DIDN'T ANSWER



Yasser Hanafi

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A Novel

—

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Prologue: Before the Morning

*There are men who carry the world's questions in their eyes and
leave the world's answers to others.*

There are cities that have no names. Not because no one thought to give them one, but because every name ever offered slipped off them like water off polished stone, leaving no trace, no impression, no claim. This was such a city.

It rose from the flatlands the way all cities rise , from necessity, then habit, then inertia , and it had been rising for so long that no one alive remembered anything before it. Its streets were old. Its buildings were older. The stones in its central square had been worn smooth by ten thousand winters, ten thousand summers, and the shuffle of feet belonging to people who had long since dissolved into the ordinary anonymity of history.

The man had lived in the city for as long as he could remember, which was a phrase he used carefully, because his memory did not begin so much as it condensed , the way a fog might, gradually, become a recognizable shape. There had always been this city. There had always been these streets. There had always been the hollow knock of his shoes on stone and the feeling, persistent and weightless, that he was moving through a world that had been arranged before his arrival and would continue after his departure without significant alteration.

He was not a difficult man, not in the way people usually mean. He paid his rent. He ate his meals. He observed the social niceties that keep strangers from becoming enemies. He held doors open. He stepped aside on staircases. He gave way on narrow pavements with a small, courteous nod. He was, by most visible measures, perfectly ordinary.

It was only when asked to explain himself , his opinions, his origins, his intentions , that something in him went quiet in a way that unnerved people. Not rudely quiet. Not defensively quiet. Simply and absolutely quiet, the way a stone is quiet, the way the sky at four in the morning is quiet: not empty, but complete.

He had been this way, as far as he could tell, since the day he first understood that most of the questions people asked each other were not requests for information but auditions , tests of loyalty, calls for solidarity, invitations to agree. He had attended enough of these auditions to know that he was not suited for them. He could not perform certainty he did not feel. He could not manufacture conviction from the thin air of other people's expectations.

So he had stopped trying. And in stopping, he had become, to the city's inhabitants, a kind of mystery , the man who stood among them and yet was not quite of them, who moved in their currents without adding to their noise.

What follows is a single day in that life. One day among countless ordinary days. But days, like stones, sometimes catch the light in ways that make them extraordinary.

This is that day.

Chapter One: Dawn & Emptiness

The city breathes differently at dawn. Before the questions begin.

He woke at four forty-seven in the morning, which was not unusual. His body had long abandoned the pretense of sleeping until alarm clocks insisted. Sleep, for him, was not so much a destination as a passage, a corridor walked in darkness that delivered him, without ceremony, back to the world.

The ceiling above his bed was water-stained in the shape of what might have been a country, might have been a cloud, might have been nothing at all. He lay still for a moment and studied it. He had studied it most mornings for three years without reaching any conclusions, and he found this comfortable. Not everything needed to resolve into something recognizable.

He rose. He moved through the small apartment in the practised dark, touching familiar surfaces, the cool edge of the dresser, the wooden arm of the chair by the window, the particular smoothness of the bathroom tap that had been turned so many thousands of times it had become as intimate as a handshake between old acquaintances. He washed his face with cold water and studied himself in the mirror without judgment. A man looking back. Average in the way that all faces are average until you spend enough time with them. His eyes, he had been told, were the complicated part.

By five-fifteen he was dressed and standing at the window. The city below was not awake, but it was not asleep either. It existed in the particular suspension of pre-dawn, that liminal hour when the streetlamps still held authority and the sky had not yet

committed to any particular color. He watched a newspaper delivery man stack papers outside the café across the street. The man moved with the mechanical efficiency of

someone who has performed the same action four thousand times and has stopped considering it. He did not look up.

At five-thirty, the man put on his coat and descended the stairs.

* * *

The city in early morning had a texture different from any other hour. He had noticed this long ago and had no particular explanation for it, but the observation pleased him. The streets held onto their shadows longer than they should. The air carried a mineral coolness that the afternoon would burn away. His footsteps on the pavement sounded measured and distinct, each one audible, as if the city were listening.

He walked without destination, which was not aimlessness. He walked the way a sailor might move around a ship, purposelessly but not uselessly, maintaining contact with the thing itself, keeping a kind of faith with it. He knew every variation in this route: the cobblestones that tilted inward near the lamppost at the corner of the square, the alley that smelled of rust and something faintly floral he had never identified, the building with the blue door whose paint peeled in the same configuration every winter and was repainted every spring, reliably, like leaves.

He turned into the main square.

It was here, at the center, that the fountain stood.

He had thought about this fountain more than he had thought about most things. Not obsessively, he was not, by nature, obsessive, but with a quiet, persistent attention. It had been dry for as long as he had lived in the city. The basin was deep and circular, made of pale stone that had grayed with age. Cracks ran through it in fine networks, like the lines in old hands. At the center, a figure had once stood, a woman or a god or a suggestion of both, arms raised as if offering or pleading, but time and weather had softened her into something ambiguous. She still raised her arms. Whatever she had once meant was no longer available.

He sat on the fountain's edge. The stone was cold through his coat.

He did not ask himself why the fountain had stopped working. He did not ask himself what had once flowed through it or when. He simply sat with the fact of its dryness, its cracked basin, its ambiguous figure with raised arms, and felt, as he always did in this spot, a kind of wordless recognition. The world was full of things that had once been something and were now something else. The fountain had been built around an expectation , of water, of movement, of the continuous renewal that running water promises , and the expectation had not been met. And yet the fountain stood. And he came back to it.

There was something clarifying in that.

He reached into his coat pocket and took out a small notebook. He did not write in it. He held it. He had carried it for years and had filled perhaps twelve pages , not with words, mostly, but with small diagrams, with the outlines of objects he had looked at for long enough that his hand began to move. He opened it to the last entry: a rough sketch of this fountain, made two winters ago, and around the fountain's edge, smaller, the outlines of questions he could not shape into language. Marks, not words. Intentions without destinations.

He closed the notebook.

A pigeon landed at his feet, regarded him with the orange clarity of a bird's unself-conscious gaze, and departed. Somewhere several streets away, a door opened and closed. The sky was beginning to lighten in the east, a pale gradation from black to the color of old bone.

He stood, adjusted his coat, and walked toward the glass-doored building at the far end of the square.

* * *

The building served some civic function he had never clearly identified. It was neither a post office nor a registry office nor a records hall, and yet it partook of all three in the way that municipal buildings sometimes do , as if the city had decided that bureaucracy, conducted at sufficient scale, becomes its own category of experience. People came and

~~He did not, with his distillation of the building's~~ He processed these transactions with the slow gravity of an institution that has existed long enough to confuse its own procedures with natural law.

He pushed open the glass door. A small bell above it announced his entry with a tone so faint it was almost apologetic.

The interior was lit by the particular fluorescent light that belongs exclusively to government offices, neither warm nor cold, but suspended at a frequency specifically designed to make everyone appear slightly ill. Dust motes drifted through it with hypnotic patience. The floor was made of tiles that had once been cream-colored and were now the color of old tea. The room smelled of paper and the particular staleness of air that has been recirculated too many times.

Behind the high counter sat a woman of perhaps forty-five, cataloging forms in the mechanical way of someone who has found peace with repetition. She wore her hair pinned back with a precision that suggested it had been pinned back in exactly this way every morning for a considerable number of years. When he approached, she looked up with the reflexive attentiveness of a professional, not warmth, exactly, but readiness.

'Name?' she said. Her voice was efficient and not unkind. The question was entirely routine.

He did not answer.

He stood at the counter for a moment, and then he reached into his breast pocket and placed a card on the counter's surface. It was a small white card, perfectly blank. He set it down gently, with some deliberateness, and then folded his hands and waited.

The clerk looked at the card. She looked at him. She looked at the card again.

Something shifted in her expression, not quite alarm, not quite irritation, but a recalibration, the way a face adjusts when the situation it had prepared for turns out to be a different situation than expected. She picked up the card, turned it over, found the back equally blank, and set it down again.

'I need a name,' she said, with the careful patience of someone who is committed to remaining professional under unexpectedly strange circumstances. 'For the form.'

He did not answer. He did not appear to be refusing so much as simply standing there, present and unhurried, as if the question were weather, something to observe rather than respond to.

A child near the waiting area tugged at her mother's sleeve. 'Mama,' the girl whispered, her voice carrying with the unconscious clarity of the very young, 'why isn't he talking?'

The mother smiled faintly, the reflexive smile of a parent managing a moment, and looked toward the man. He made no gesture of acknowledgment. He stood with his hands folded on the counter and his eyes on the middle distance, patient as stone.

The clerk turned to the tall man in the dark coat who had been standing behind her, reviewing something on a clipboard. She said, quietly, as if she were reporting a minor administrative anomaly: 'He won't speak.'

The man in the dark coat looked up. He set down the clipboard with the deliberate care of someone who is accustomed to making every gesture signify authority. He was perhaps fifty, with the kind of face that has spent enough time being serious that seriousness has become its default configuration. He approached the counter.

'Good morning,' he said. His tone was measured, the tone of a man who has negotiated a great many situations and understands that tone is itself a negotiation. 'Can you answer a question for us?'

He studied the official with the same quality of attention he gave everything, quiet, thorough, without particular conclusion. He did not nod. He did not shake his head. He simply continued to be present.

Outside, a clocktower somewhere struck seven bells. Each tone fell into the silence of the office and was absorbed by it.

The official let out a breath that was almost, but not quite, a sigh. He looked at the blank card on the counter. He looked at the man standing calmly on the other side of it. He

reached some internal determination that this was not, at least for the moment, an emergency.

'All right,' he said quietly, more to himself than anyone. 'All right.'

He stepped back. He gestured, with the slightly helpless politeness of a man who is unsure of the protocol, for the man to proceed.

The man straightened his coat, lifted his hat slightly in the direction of the clerk , a small, grave acknowledgment , and walked through the hall.

Chapter Two: Encounter & Question

We ask 'who are you?' because we cannot bear the answer that some people give by simply being.

The building's interior unfolded as he moved through it: a sequence of corridors and antechambers, of small offices visible through glass partitions, of noticeboards dense with the municipal poetry of notices, memos, schedules, and official reminders about fire safety and the proper disposal of documents. He walked without urgency, taking it all in with the unhurried attention of a man who has nowhere in particular to be and is at peace with this.

The others in the hallway , a man with a briefcase, a woman balancing a stack of folders, a boy sent on some errand who was failing to look purposeful , gave him the various glances that his silence tended to attract: a quick assessment, a slight puzzlement, a redirecting of attention. No one spoke to him. He spoke to no one.

He found a window at the end of a long corridor and stopped. It looked out onto the back of the square , a different angle on the fountain, smaller from here, its raised figure barely distinguishable from the surrounding stone. Beyond it, the city was waking up: a bakery's vent releasing warm air, shop owners arranging displays, pigeons negotiating the geometry of rooftops with their usual municipal gravity.

He stood and watched and did not think about what he was watching in any systematic way. He simply watched, the way you might watch rain, or fire: not for information, but for the particular comfort of things that move according to their own logic.

* * *

It was Vera who came to stand beside him.

She was a colleague in the building , not his colleague exactly, since he held no official position there, but a person who existed in the same institutional space and had, over time, developed a cautious familiarity with him. She was perhaps thirty-five, with an expression that had settled into a kind of habitual thoughtfulness, as if she were perpetually in the early stages of working something out. She carried herself with the particular efficiency of someone who is competent and knows it without needing to announce it.

'You're back,' she said. Not as an accusation. More as a fact she was verifying.

He turned slightly to acknowledge her presence , a fraction of a turn, barely perceptible, but deliberate. He returned his attention to the window.

She followed his gaze. Outside, in the courtyard below, a small boy had dropped an ice cream cone. He was on his knees on the pavement, staring at the spreading pink ~~with the~~ specific devastation of a child who has not yet learned to distinguish between losses that can be recovered from and losses that cannot. His lower lip trembled. He did not cry, which somehow made it worse.

The man watched him. Something in his stillness changed , not dramatically, not in a way that would have been visible across the room, but a slight softening, a loosening at the edges.

~~Vera just stared at him, almost to herself,~~ because she heard herself, and because there was something in the way the man was looking at the boy that made the phrase feel insufficient: 'But I suppose at that age it isn't, really.'

He did not respond. But neither did he look away from the boy until the child's mother appeared, crouched beside him, said something in his ear, and led him away by the hand. After they had gone, the man remained looking at the empty pavement for another moment, and then turned from the window and walked down the corridor.

Vera fell into step beside him, because she was going that way too, and because something about walking beside him had always felt easier than it should have.

* * *

The office they entered was occupied by several people in various attitudes of waiting: a man in overalls reading a newspaper that he held upside down without seeming to notice, a woman knitting something complicated that she regarded with professional severity, an elderly gentleman who appeared to be asleep and would occasionally

produce a small sound, not quite a snore, that suggested he was at peace.

He stood behind Vera as she attended to the day's ordinary transactions. He did not sit. He stood with his hands in his pockets and watched the room with the quality of attention that was, by now, recognizable to those who had encountered him before: not the attention of observation, exactly, but of witness. There was a difference, and most people sensed it without being able to articulate it.

One by one, the people waiting became aware of him. Whispers moved through the room with the discrete momentum of a thing that everyone pretends isn't happening. He noticed this, he noticed everything, and did not adjust his behavior in response. He simply continued to stand.

'Your name,' Vera said gently, turning to him with a pen and a form, after the others had been attended to. She said it as a question, though she had already guessed the answer.

Or rather, she had already guessed that there would not be one.

He looked at the form for a moment. He took the pen from her hand with a small nod of thanks. At the bottom of the form, in the space designated for signature, he drew a single horizontal line, not quite a signature, not quite nothing, and returned the pen.

Vera looked at the line for a moment.

'I see,' she said. And she seemed, actually, to see something, though she could not have said precisely what.

Behind her, the official had reappeared in the doorway. He surveyed the room with the slightly proprietorial air of a man who considers himself responsible for a space and takes this responsibility seriously. When his gaze landed on the man, something shifted in his expression, a recognition, a gathering of intention.

'We'll have to note it,' he said to Vera. 'Incomplete forms are incomplete.' The words were official, but his tone had something uncertain in it, something that suggested he was aware, even as he spoke, that the usual categories were not quite applying.

Vera picked up the form. She looked at the line where the name should have been. She looked at the man. She looked back at the form. And then, with the quiet decisiveness of someone who has decided that a situation requires its own solution, she wrote in the space provided, in her careful handwriting: The Man Who Didn't Answer.

He watched her write it. He felt nothing that he would have called anything in particular, not amusement, not vindication, not discomfort. He felt, perhaps, the particular equilibrium of a thing that has found its accurate name.

Chapter Three: Glance & Gossip

What we cannot explain, we discuss. What we cannot discuss, we carry.

By mid-morning, he had become a story.

This was not unusual. People become stories when they refuse to explain themselves, because explanation is the material from which other people construct their understanding of you, and in the absence of material, they will construct from whatever is available, observation, inference, imagination, the sediment of their own fears and curiosities. The story that had gathered around him by mid-morning was not dramatic. It was the kind of low-level murmur that moves through a workplace like a change in air pressure, felt rather than heard.

'Have you seen the new one?'

'He doesn't say anything. Just stands there.'

'Maybe he's foreign. Maybe he doesn't speak the language.'

'He understands perfectly well. You can see it in his face.'

'Then why doesn't he,'

'I don't know. That's what I'm saying.'

He heard fragments of this as he moved through the corridors, not because anyone was speaking loudly but because the building carried sound in the particular way of old structures, through its ducts and stairwells and the gaps under doors, so that conversations arrived in pieces, decontextualized, like quotations from a book he hadn't read. He did not find it troubling. He understood that he was, from the outside,

puzzling. He had always been puzzling from the outside. He had simply reached a point at which the puzzlement of others no longer puzzled him.

* * *

Lena found him in the courtyard.

She was perhaps thirty, with the warm, slightly scattered energy of someone who approaches the world with genuine enthusiasm and is perpetually surprised by the results. She worked in a department he had never clearly identified, something to do with forms, or the filing of forms, or the provision of forms to people who needed them, and she had a quality of relentless friendliness that was, he had found, entirely sincere. She was not friendly because she was trying to be. She was friendly because she had not yet found sufficient reason not to be, and this struck him, privately, as one of the more

interesting stances available to a person.

'There you are!' she said, with the relieved warmth of someone who has been looking for a person they were not entirely sure they would find. 'I've been looking for you everywhere.'

He looked at her. She had a smudge of ink on her left wrist, a coffee cup in one hand, and a clipboard balanced under the same arm with the precarious confidence of someone accustomed to carrying too many things.

'Are you coming to lunch? I have a sandwich if you're hungry.'

He shook his head slowly. Then, for reasons he would not have been able to fully articulate, a response to some quality in the morning light, or simply the instinct to share a thing worth sharing, he pointed upward, toward a cloud that had drifted across the sun and was momentarily positioned in the shape of something interesting.

Lena looked up. She studied the cloud with sincere attention for several seconds. The cloud, being a cloud, continued to be ambiguous.

'The sky,' she said, uncertainly.

He looked at her. The corner of his mouth shifted by approximately two millimeters in a direction that was not quite a smile but was in the neighborhood of one.

'All right,' she said. 'I'm going to eat. Do you want to come along? Just us. It's quiet.' She paused. 'Well. Quiet on my end might be relative, but I'll try.'

He nodded once and began to walk.

* * *

They walked through a part of the city that had the particular character of areas that were once something and are now being slowly converted into something else, without quite completing the transformation. Old shopfronts showed behind new signs. Buildings wore their renovation like awkward new clothes. The street had the unresolved quality of a sentence that has been interrupted mid-clause.

Lena talked, not because she was nervous , or not only because she was nervous , but because talking was how she moved through the world. She noted things as they passed: the new café that had replaced the old florist, the street artist who had added something to the wall of the old postal sorting office, the particular configuration of pigeons on the roof of the building with the blue door.

He walked beside her and listened, which he did well. Listening was something he had practiced extensively, partly from necessity and partly because he had discovered that most people, when listened to with genuine attention, said things of considerably more interest than they themselves realized.

'Did you sleep all right last night?' she asked, in the particular way that people ask questions they are not entirely sure they should ask.

He did not answer. But he made a small movement , the kind of movement that might simply have been the beginning of his acknowledgment that the question had arrived , and something in his expression shifted, so subtly that you might have missed it, to a quality that was not quite warmth but was

something adjacent to it.

Lena bit her lip. She seemed to decide something.

They passed a painter who was working on a door , a deep green, applied with methodical strokes. The painter did not look up. Lena glanced at him, then at the man beside her, with the slight suppressed amusement of someone who finds the combination of silences unexpectedly funny.

'He's certainly in his element,' she said, and then immediately felt that this was not the right thing to have said, and lapsed into a companionable quiet that lasted until they reached the bench.

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The courtyard was small and enclosed on three sides by buildings, open on the fourth to a narrow lane. A tree grew in the center , a plane tree, old and thick-trunked, its bark peeling in abstract patterns , and the bench beneath it had been worn smooth by

generations of people who had sat there to eat or rest or be temporarily invisible from the demands of the surrounding city.

Lena distributed the contents of two paper bags with the efficient generosity of someone who takes hospitality seriously even in informal circumstances. A sandwich in wax paper. An apple. A small piece of cake wrapped in foil.

He accepted these items with a gravity that made them feel, briefly, important.

They ate. The tree moved slightly in a wind he had not noticed until now. Somewhere in the lane, a bicycle passed. The city continued its operations.

After a while, Lena said: 'You remind me of that fountain. In the square.' She did not preface this or explain it , it came out the way that things come out when you've been thinking them for a while and they've finally accumulated enough weight to require expression. 'You know, the one that doesn't work.'

He stopped eating. He looked at her.

She continued, more slowly now: 'It still stands, even though it's been broken for years. And it's strange , sometimes people walk past it and don't even notice it's not working. They just see the fountain and they think it's all right. Because it's still there, and it still looks like a fountain, and it still has the figure in the middle with her arms raised.' She paused. 'But then sometimes I look at it and I wonder what it's waiting for. Whether it knows something we don't, or whether it just... doesn't know what else to do.'

He looked at her for a long time. His eyes, which were usually held with a certain careful distance, were entirely present.

'Anyway,' she said, embarrassed now by the length of her own reflection, 'that's probably not what I meant to say.' She picked up her apple and looked at it as though reconsidering its relevance to the situation. 'Sorry.'

He shook his head. A single, slow movement. Not the negation of a claim. The dismissal of an apology. The gesture said: don't be.

They finished eating in silence. It was, he thought , though thinking was not quite the right word for what he did in those moments , a good silence. Not empty. Not heavy.

Simply the silence of two people who have found they do not need to fill a space to share it.

Chapter Four: Confrontation

Authority is only ever asking one question. We dress it up, but that is always the question: Who are you and what are you doing here?

The official's name was Mirko, though this is not a detail the man ever learned. He was known in the building as a fair man, which in the context of bureaucratic assessment means someone who applies the rules consistently and without visible pleasure. He had worked in the building for twenty-two years. He had processed thousands of forms, conducted hundreds of interviews, navigated the bureaucratic equivalent of uncountable storms. He was, by his own assessment, not unreasonable.

But the man who didn't answer was presenting him with a category problem. And category problems, in Mirko's experience, were the genuinely difficult ones, more difficult than outright violations, because at least violations had clear procedures attached to them. Category problems required judgment, and judgment required a kind of exposure that the application of rules conveniently avoided.

He had spent the morning thinking about this.

By afternoon, he had decided to try once more.

* * *

He found the man standing at a window in the eastern corridor, a different window from the morning, but the same quality of looking: attentive, patient, apparently untroubled by the fact that windows eventually require you to turn away.

'I wonder if I might have a word,' Mirko said. He was aware, even as he said it, of the faint incongruity of the phrase in context.

The man turned from the window. He studied Mirko with the quality of attention that Mirko, by this point, was beginning to recognize: careful, unhurried, entirely without aggression.

He gestured down the corridor, toward the small office he kept. The man followed.

* * *

The office was the kind of room that accumulates personality through use rather than decoration. A desk, functional and cluttered. A bookshelf dense with binders labeled in the dry shorthand of administrative categories. A window that looked onto a light-well and received, consequently, a quality of illumination that had the character of an afterthought. A photograph on the desk, a family, smiling in the manner of photographs, and beside it, a coffee mug bearing the logo of an institution whose name had been partly obscured by a chip in the ceramic.

They sat on opposite sides of the desk. The man in the chair, upright and unhurried. Mirko in his usual position, which he adjusted slightly before settling, the habitual adjustment of a man accustomed to the authority of his own space.

'I want to be straightforward with you,' Mirko said. He folded his hands on the desk. 'We have incomplete documentation. That creates problems for us, practical problems, administrative ones. I'm not suggesting anything improper on your part. I simply need to understand what's happening so that we can proceed correctly.' He paused. 'So. Why won't you speak to us?'

The man looked at the desk surface between them. It held a stack of forms, a pen, an ink stamp, and a small glass paperweight that had been positioned, perhaps unconsciously, exactly at the desk's center. He regarded all of these things without particular emphasis.

'Your name,' Mirko tried. 'Your date of birth. A signature. Anything.'

The man was quiet for a moment. Then he did something unexpected. He raised his hand slowly and pointed upward, toward the wall above the bookshelf, where an old clock hung. The clock had a face, and the face had numbers, and the space where the

hands should have been was empty. It had been like this for several years. Mirko had grown so accustomed to it that he no longer saw it.

'The clock,' Mirko said. 'What about,'

The man lowered his pointing hand. He placed it flat on his own chest. He tapped it twice, very lightly. Then he held very still.

Mirko frowned. He looked at the man's hand on his chest. He looked at the man's face.

'Your... heartbeat?'

The man said nothing. But something in his expression , some loosening, some almost imperceptible acknowledgment , suggested that this was closer to it. Or at least, that this was in the direction of it.

Mirko sat back in his chair. He was quiet for a moment that had a different quality from his previous silences , not the silence of a man gathering his position, but the silence of a man who has unexpectedly lost it.

'I don't understand what you're telling me,' he said at last. And there was something in his voice that had not been there before , something that had the texture of honesty. 'I genuinely don't understand.'

The man's lips moved. They moved in what might have been the beginning of something , a word, or the shape of a word, or simply the physical echo of the impulse toward speech , and then they were still.

He looked directly at Mirko. For a moment, the distance that he usually maintained between himself and the world , that careful, habitual, unaggressive remove , was not exactly absent, but it was thinner. Something was visible through it. Mirko, who had spent twenty-two years in a job that required him to read people, looked back at it and felt, to his considerable surprise, something that he would have been deeply reluctant to name.

'All I wanted,' he said quietly, 'was your name. So that we know who you are.' He heard himself say this and felt, for the first time, how strange a thing it was to say. So that we know who you are. As if a name did that. As if it had ever done that.

The man looked at him for another moment. Then he did something that Mirko thought about for a long time afterward. He shook his head , slowly, gently, with no defiance in it , and he closed his eyes.

It was not a refusal. It was something else. A completion, perhaps. Or a release.

They sat in silence until the clock on the wall, which had no hands and kept no time, seemed anyway to mark something.

* * *

Vera had been listening from the doorway , she had come with something for Mirko to sign and had found herself unable to interrupt. When the silence between the two men reached a length that felt resolved, she stepped back into the corridor.

She stood there for a moment, holding the unsigned papers, and tried to work out what it was she had just witnessed.

She could not precisely say. But she thought that whatever it was, it was not nothing.

Chapter Five: Reverie & Reflection

*The question inside you does not always require an answer.
Sometimes it only requires company.*

Evening came to the city with the particular exhausted beauty of days that have been long without being eventful. The light turned gold and then amber and then, by degrees, the specific gray of approaching night. The streets shifted their population: the day-people withdrew, the evening-people emerged, and for a short period both occupied the same space with the mutual tolerance of creatures whose schedules happen to overlap.

He walked home the long way.

This was not, technically, a choice, or not a conscious one. His feet had simply declined the shortcut and taken him instead along the river road, where the water reflected the last of the light and the trees on the far bank were dark shapes against a darkening sky. He had walked this route before, many times, and it always had the quality of a conversation he was having with himself, or rather, with the part of himself that did not use words, which was the larger part.

He thought about the official. He thought about the fountain. He thought about Lena and her comparison, which had landed somewhere precise and stayed there, the way well-aimed observations do.

He thought, though thought was again not quite the right word, about what he was. Not in the existential way that people sometimes asked themselves this question, with its undertow of urgency and its implication that the answer mattered for something. More in the way that you might look at an object you own and know well and think: yes, that's what that is. Acknowledging, without drama, the fact of the thing.

He was a man who did not answer. This was simply true, and it had become more simply true over the years, the way rivers become more themselves as they move further from their sources , widening, deepening, acquiring their particular character from the land they have passed through.

He was not silent because he had nothing to say. He was silent because the things he might say did not feel like improvements on silence. He had tried, in earlier years, to explain this and had found that explanation was itself a kind of defeat , that the moment you begin justifying your silence, you have already capitulated to the assumption that silence requires justification, which was precisely the assumption he declined.

The river caught a final streak of light and held it for a moment. He stopped to watch.

* * *

The apartment was as he had left it.

This was something he found consistently reassuring: that things remained where he left them, that his absence from a space did not require its rearrangement. The chair by the window. The lamp on the table. The stack of old photographs that he had moved from the closet some weeks ago and had not yet decided what to do with.

He sat near the window. The city spread below him in its evening configuration , lights appearing in windows, a couple walking a dog along the pavement, the dog investigating something of apparently great significance at the base of a lamppost.

He reached for the photographs.

There were perhaps twenty of them, old and slightly faded at the edges in the way of photographs that have been handled enough times to have absorbed something of their handlers. He went through them slowly. They documented , imprecisely, incompletely , a life that was recognizably his, though it sometimes surprised him to see himself in them. A younger face. Different contexts. The particular poses that people adopt for

cameras, which are always slightly more confident, slightly more settled in their inhabitation of themselves, than the poses they adopt for the ordinary world.

In one of them he was standing in front of a window, looking out at something. He could not remember the city or the window or what he had been looking at. He was smiling slightly, not for the camera, which was what made the photograph unusual, smiling at whatever he was looking at, or at some thought that had arrived at exactly that moment.

The smile had the quality of a private thing.

He set the photograph down and looked at his hands.

He thought about what the official had said. All I wanted was your name. So that we know who you are. He had never doubted that this was true. Mirko had wanted to know who he was, in the way that all the official forms and procedures were a way of asking who you were, reducing the complexity of a person to a set of data points stable enough to be processed, filed, referenced. He understood the logic. He did not object to it. He simply recognized that the answer it provided was always a simplification, and he was constitutionally unsuited to offering simplifications when he was aware of them as such.

Who are you.

A man who sits by a broken fountain and feels, without being able to say why, that this is important.

A man who watches a child lose an ice cream cone and feels, without being able to articulate it, the specific weight of irreversible small losses.

A man who carries a notebook with twelve pages of marks that are not words and is at peace with this.

A man who does not know, and has decided, after long consideration and not without some cost, to remain honestly in that not-knowing rather than paper over it with the confident noises that others seem to manage so effortlessly.

This was not something that fit in a form.

* * *

The knock at the door came at eight-fifteen. He knew it was Vera before he opened it , not by any particular premonition, but by a quality in the knock itself: tentative but resolved, the knock of someone who has decided to do something and is going to do it despite reservations.

She was holding a small cup of tea. She had covered the top of it with a saucer.

'I thought,' she said, and paused, and started again: 'I thought maybe you'd want this. Company. Or not company. Just the tea.' She looked briefly embarrassed. 'I found out where you live from the files. I hope that's all right. I realize that's,' she paused again, 'I realize that might seem strange.'

He stepped back from the door. The gesture was clear.

She came in and sat in the chair across from his. He sat in his own chair. She handed him the tea. He held it in both hands and felt its warmth, which was the particular warmth of something prepared by someone else , a different quality from self-provided warmth, something in it that was not just temperature.

They were quiet for a while. It was a productive quiet , the kind that precedes something rather than following it.

Vera looked around the room with the careful, non-intrusive attention of someone who is trying to understand a space without appropriating it. She noticed the photographs on the table. She noticed the notebook beside them. She noticed the quality of the room, which was spare but not empty, orderly but not sterile , the room of someone who had organized their life around the minimum of what was required and found it sufficient.

'I still don't understand,' she said at last. 'Why you do this.' She paused. 'And I know you can speak. I heard you , in the office, earlier. You said something to Mirko.'

He looked at the tea.

'I like tea without asking,' he said. His voice was quiet and a little unpracticed , the voice of someone who uses speech selectively enough that it retains the texture of something considered. 'Someone made it for me. That's all.'

Vera stared at him for a moment. 'That's the first thing you've said to me,' she said. And then: 'That's almost the first thing I've heard you say to anyone.'

He looked at her. 'I know.'

She sat with this for a moment. 'Why those words? Of all the words?'

He seemed to consider this question , not in the way of a person deciding whether to answer, but in the way of a person making sure they understand what they actually think before attempting to say it.

'Sometimes,' he said slowly, 'I feel a question inside me. And I wait for it to become something I can put into words. Most of the time it doesn't. Most of the time it stays as a question.' He paused. 'I'm not sure there are answers. I'm not sure there are even words for the questions. But waiting for the right words feels more honest than using the wrong ones.'

Vera looked at him for a long time. Her expression was complicated in the way that expressions become when they're trying to accommodate something that doesn't fit the usual categories.

'I think,' she said finally, 'I think that makes more sense than you probably expect it to.'

He looked at her and said nothing. But his eyes, which were usually held at a slight remove, were entirely present. And that was enough.

She squeezed his hand briefly when she stood to leave , a small, decided gesture, the kind that means: I have understood what I can. She moved to the door, and then stopped, and said without turning: 'The fountain in the square. I looked it up. It was built as a memorial to someone. No one remembers who now. Isn't that something?'

He didn't respond. But in the silence he left, she heard something. She nodded once, almost to herself, and left.

He sat for a long time afterward, holding the empty cup, looking at the city lights.

Chapter Six: Nightfall & Acceptance

To live without answers is not to live in darkness. It is to live in the only honest light there is.

At midnight, he put on his coat and went out.

The city at midnight had a different character from the city at dawn. Where dawn was tentative, midnight was certain, certain of its darkness, its quiet, its particular quality of suspension. The streets were not empty but they were underpopulated, occupied by the ~~that boy of people who made the mistake of thinking that the others belong out there~~ midnight people, a kind of courtesy that did not exist at other hours, a mutual acknowledgment of

outsideness that precluded the usual performances.

He walked to the square.

The fountain was silver in the moonlight. He had not expected to be surprised by this, and he was not, exactly, surprised, but he stopped when he saw it, the way you stop when something you know suddenly presents itself at an angle that reveals it differently. The pale stone had turned luminous. The cracks in the basin were shadow. The figure at the center, the ambiguous woman-god with her raised arms, was, in this light, entirely resolved. She was not offering and she was not pleading. She was simply standing in the dark with her arms up, as if she had decided that this was the appropriate posture for

the situation and had not found sufficient reason to change it.

He sat on the edge of the basin. The stone was cold. He did not mind.

* * *

He thought about what Vera had told him. The fountain built as a memorial to someone no one remembered. He looked at the figure and thought about that , the particular fate of being commemorated for a while and then forgotten, of being the reason for a thing that eventually outlasts any knowledge of the reason. The fountain had been built with intent, with significance, with the weight of grief or gratitude or both. And now it stood in the square and it was dry and its subject was unknown and people walked past it and came to sit on its edge and sketch it in notebooks and compare themselves to it and none of this was what it had been built for.

And it was still a fountain.

That was the thing. It was still a fountain. Whatever it had been built for, it was still itself. The water had gone. The name had gone. The reason had gone. But the stone remained, and the form remained, and the figure remained with her arms up in the patient posture of someone who has not yet been told to put them down.

He sat with this for a long time.

* * *

Around one in the morning, a boy appeared at the far end of the square.

He was perhaps fifteen or sixteen , the age at which everything is slightly too large, when the body and the world both feel like clothes that don't quite fit. He walked with the particular self-consciousness of someone who doesn't know he's being self-conscious, which is to say the particular self-consciousness of being fifteen or sixteen. He was crying, quietly and with some effort to conceal it, in the way of a person who has decided that crying is a private activity and is only doing it in the square at one in the morning because the square at one in the morning was the most private space he had been able to

find.

He sat on the steps of a building opposite the fountain and put his face in his hands.

The man watched him for a moment. He did not immediately approach. He considered. He thought about all the reasons to not approach a crying stranger in the middle of the

night , the probable desire for privacy, the uncertainty of reception, the difficulty of offering comfort in the absence of words. He thought about all of this and then he stood, walked across the square, and sat down a few feet from the boy on the steps.

The boy heard him and looked up, startled, and then, when he saw that the man had simply sat down and was not looking at him but at the fountain, the alarm passed from his face. He wiped his eyes with the back of his hand. He looked at the man, then at the fountain, then back at the man.

He did not ask the man who he was or why he was there. The hour and the square made those questions irrelevant.

They sat in silence , a silence that was not empty but occupied, not heavy but present. After a while, the boy's breathing steadied. The particular tightness in his shoulders began to release. He was not, by the end of it, happy , whatever had brought him to the square in the middle of the night had not been resolved. But he was, by the end of it, returned to himself. The silence had made room for him. That was enough.

When the boy finally stood to leave, he looked at the man for a moment. He did not say anything. He gave a small, slightly awkward nod , the nod of someone who wants to acknowledge something without knowing quite what it is , and walked away.

The man watched him go.

* * *

He sat alone again in the square. The night had moved past its deepest point and was beginning, almost imperceptibly, to relent. Above him, the stars were precise and cold , the particular precision of things that have been there long enough that they have stopped apologizing for what they are.

He thought: I have no answers.

He thought: I have never had answers. I have tried, at various points, to perform the having of them. I have tried certainty on like a coat and found it did not fit. I have listened to people offer their certainties , in the language of conviction, in the language

of faith, in the language of ideology, in the simple daily language of I know , and I have felt, in each case, the same specific unease. Not hostility. Not superiority. Just the sensation of someone watching a dance they cannot quite learn the steps to, even when they want to.

He thought: the questions are not a problem to be solved. They are the landscape. You live in them. You move through them. You do not wait to arrive at certainty before beginning , you begin, and you let certainty be what it is, which is occasional, temporary, and not the point.

He thought: I do not know what this fountain was built for. I do not know what happened to the person it commemorates, or whether that person's life was good or difficult or somewhere in between. I do not know what water felt like falling through this basin in the years when water did fall through it. I know only that the stone is here, and I am here, and the night is here, and the stars, and these are not nothing.

He looked up at the sky.

A cloud moved across a portion of stars, and in moving revealed a portion of other stars, and he watched this transaction with the full attention he gave everything , which was not analytical attention, not interpretive attention, but the simple, honest attention of a person who is present to a thing without requiring it to mean something beyond itself.

He breathed out slowly. And in the space of that breath, something that had been held , not tightly, but persistently, in the way that a door holds even when it is not locked , opened slightly. Not into revelation. Not into certainty. Into a quality of space that was enough.

He was not certain. He had never been certain, and the pretense of certainty had always cost him something he couldn't spare. But he was here. He was awake. He had sat beside a crying boy in the middle of the night and offered the only thing he had , silence and presence , and it had, apparently, been what was needed. He had drunk tea given to him without obligation and found it warm. He had sat by a dry fountain and found it sufficient company. He had moved through a day of questions without answers and

found that, somehow, the day had still moved.

This was not happiness, exactly. Or not only happiness. It was something larger than happiness and more specific , a quality of being that did not require happiness as a prerequisite, that contained both the sorrow of uncertainty and the peace of having stopped fighting it.

* * *

The sky to the east began to lighten. Almost imperceptibly at first , a lessening of darkness rather than an arrival of light. Then the specific pale that he had woken to every morning for years began to gather at the horizon, and the city began to resume its slow preparation for the day.

He sat and watched it.

He did not think: this is beautiful. He did not think: this is meaningful. He simply let it happen, the way you let something happen when you have accepted that you are not its author and are not responsible for its interpretation.

When the first real light appeared , not dawn yet, but the harbinger of dawn, the light that precedes the light , he stood. His joints were stiff from the cold stone. He stretched, carefully, and felt the ordinary morning protest of a body that has been stationary for too long.

He looked at the fountain. At the figure with her arms raised. At the light beginning to catch the stone.

She was still asking. Or offering. Or simply standing. He had never decided which, and now he thought he did not need to. She was doing what she did. He was doing what he did. The city was doing what it did.

He put his hands in his pockets and walked toward home.

Behind him, the fountain caught the first light and held it for a moment , the gray stone suddenly golden, the cracks illuminated, the raised arms casting long shadows across the empty basin. Then the light shifted and it was gray again. And it was still a fountain.

And the figure still stood.

The city woke up around him as he walked. The same newspaper delivery man, the same mechanic, the same efficiency, the same place, the same coffee, the same clocktower, the same seven bells when they came, dropping through the morning air like stones dropped through water.

He walked.

He did not have answers. He did not, as he walked, feel the absence of them. He felt the morning air, which was cool and still. He felt the familiar cobblestones under his feet, the particular tilt near the lamppost at the corner of the square. He felt the weight of the notebook in his pocket and the specific quality of the day arriving, not with revelation, not with resolution, but with the patient continuation of itself.

He would sit by the fountain again tomorrow. He would walk the river road. He would drink tea if it was offered and offer presence if it was needed. He would carry his questions and not know their answers and find, in that not-knowing, the only honest ground available.

He would not answer.

And in the space of his not-answering, something would be said.

— THE END —

Epilogue: The Fountain

The fountain was built in 1887 as a memorial to a woman named Eliška Vrendt, who had done something , the records are unclear on what , that the city had deemed worth remembering. She was thirty-one years old when she died. Her name was carved into the base of the basin in letters that the weather had, by now, almost entirely erased.

She had dark hair and, by all accounts, an opinion about everything.

She would have found the silent man deeply interesting.

She would have tried, with some persistence, to get him to say something.

He would not have answered.

And she would have sat beside him in the silence, and eventually stopped trying, and felt , probably , that this was not a failure but a different kind of conversation.

This is, in the end, what the fountain was built to commemorate: not a name, not a deed, but a quality of presence. A way of being with the world that did not require the world to be otherwise.

The water is still gone. The stone is still cracked. The figure still stands with her arms raised.

The city still moves around her.

THE MAN WHO DIDN'T ANSWER

In a nameless city, a man moves through the world in quiet refusal. He pays his rent. He holds doors open. He steps aside on narrow pavements. But when asked to explain himself who he is, what he wants, why he will not speak he simply does not answer.

Over the course of a single day, he encounters a clerk who files him under the only name she can find, an official undone by a category problem he has no procedure for, a colleague who compares him to a broken fountain still standing in the square, and a boy crying alone at midnight whom he comforts without a word.

The Man Who Didn't Answer is a meditation on the courage of not knowing on what it means to live honestly inside the silence where certainty refuses to come. Spare, poetic, and quietly devastating, it asks whether the questions we carry might matter more than any answer we could give them.

Yasser Hanafi